returned to Pakistan, where he met separately with Sajid and Abdur Rehman Syed in late January, providing video surveillance to each of them. Syed passed the surveillance footage on to Kashmiri, and took Headley to meet him in North Waziristan the following month. Kashmiri said he could provide the manpower for the operation and therefore Lashkar's participation was unnecessary.[73] According to Headley's testimony to Indian investigators, he was also tasked with doing reconnaissance of targets in India. Headley asserts he did not tell Sajid about his meeting with Kashmiri, suggesting this was not a case of sharing resources.[74] Rather, Kashmiri was attempting to poach Lashkar's operative and its operation.

This was not the first time Syed had asked Headley to undertake surveillance independent of Lashkar's direction; he had done so once before in 2007 and Headley obliged by doing a quick survey of the National Defense College in Delhi. This time the mission was more extensive, and Headley spent several weeks in India during the month of March conducting surveillance for Syed who funded the trip. In Headley's estimation, Abdur Rehman was more interested in attacks against India than in the Northern Project at this point. However, it is worth noting that in addition to tasking him with reconnaissance of traditional Indian targets, including thorough surveillance of the National Defense College, Syed specifically directed Headley to survey additional Chabad Houses as well as other sites at which Israelis or other foreigners were present. After returning to Pakistan, Headley discussed with Syed all of the targets he had surveyed in detail. The latter had established a setup in Nepal during previous trips there while still working with Lashkar and suggested this network could help with launching attacks. Syed also operated a setup in Karachi dedicated to operations against India, for which Headley believes he coordinated with an ISI handler; a relationship Headley alleges continued despite the fact that Syed was working closely with Ilyas Kashmiri (responsible for a host of attacks in Pakistan) and by extension al-Qaeda.[75]

A transnational operative with an American passport was a valuable asset, and upon learning of his reconnaissance in India both Sajid and Lakhvi instructed Headley not to work with Abdur Rehman.[76] Exacerbating concerns about Headley's freelancing was the fact that the group was under heavy pressure from the ISI to lay low following the Mumbai attacks.[77] Mir